DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Happens to the Body in the Seventh Millennium?

Daat Tevunot §88-92

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §88 (second half) to §92 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 16 February 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Given at the start, then earned

We are in the middle of §88, page 212 in the English. Last time we saw that at the very beginning the soul has its full power, and is then diminished so that it knows what it can reach.

The Rabbi added a principle found throughout the Torah: very often we are given the highest level as a gift, then it is taken away, and we have to work to reach it ourselves. On the first night of Pesah a person reaches the highest levels; then it is taken away, and he has forty-nine days to work towards it. The child in the womb is taught the whole Torah, for the same reason: you are shown what you can reach, and now you must go and do it yourself.

The five levels completed

Throughout all five levels there is a body, because for the Ramhal the body worked in this world and must share in the eternal reward. The first three, reviewed from last time, are all in olam haba, after the year seven thousand:

- **Level one.** The body is completely submissive to the soul, with no will or desire of its own. Asked whether this is like the angels, the Rabbi agreed, with two differences: you have a body, and you worked for it yourself rather than being programmed.
- **Level two.** The body has vague, general recollections of the time it had desires, which very slightly limit the soul.
- **Level three.** The body is submissive but has more specific recollections, which limit the soul somewhat more.

Level four (page 212). The body is still the same body, with its drives, but it behaves like a guest. It says: I am in the soul's town, I must keep quiet. As the saying goes, when you enter a city, follow its customs. The soul is in full authority.

The Rabbi's example was Moshe Rabbenu on the mountain for forty days and nights. He did not fly off anywhere: he was on the mountain, in an intense divine revelation, and the Torah says "bread he did not eat and water he did not drink". That is not human. His body had not changed; it was the same body with the same impulses, but it was a guest and did not ask for

anything. When he came down he ate and drank again. His face shone, which was a very great thing, "but in relation to level three, it's still incomparable". At level three the body itself has been changed through death and refinement and no longer needs to drink. At level four the body still needs to drink but "is in a place where we don't do that, so we keep quiet".

Level five. The body is in full control, "ruling in its own house". This is our world. It has two forms. A person can engage with his body like an animal, eating, drinking and procreating as animals do. Or he can engage with it in holiness: "in all your ways know Him", eating and drinking for Shabbat, or in order to live, learn, pray and do misvot, as a means and not an end. But both are level five, because either way you must eat and drink. Even the greatest saddikim, even Moshe apart from his days on the mountain, had to eat and drink.

Asked why 5A and 5B are not counted as six levels, the group agreed: they are not stages in time but two kinds of people at the same time. "You're either a 5A person or a 5B person, but you're a five person."

A dial on the soul

The Ramhal says these levels correspond to how much concealment or illumination there is. The Rabbi used Mark's analogy from the previous class: a dial. The soul is the same; the question is how far the dial is closed on it. At level five it is almost fully closed, and it is a dial that closes again if you let go, so you must keep pushing. At level four it is more open, and at level one it is fully open, with only a tiny drop of concealment, until nothing at all remains for the body.

§89-91: why five?

The Neshamah asks why five. The Sekhel answers: because that is how reality is.

1. Existence without any authority.
2. Authority in general only.
3. Authority over a few details.
4. Authority over all details, but as a guest.
5. Complete control of all details, on home territory.

If you cannot remember five, remember three: the soul in complete control (levels one to three), the body with some authority (level four), and the body in full control (level five). The Ramhal says the three are what matter for our discussion, but to keep the five in mind, since some sayings of Hazal can only be understood through them.

§92: when do these times come?

The Sekhel brings two teachings of Hazal. The world exists for six thousand years, and for one thousand, the seventh millennium, it is desolate; then God renews it. And of the seventh millennium they ask what the righteous will do, and answer that God will make them wings and they will float above the water.

From this we learn the three general times:

- **The six thousand years.** The world as it is now, with the body in full control, "like a ruler in his own house, because this is his place".
- **The seventh millennium.** Tehiyat hametim takes place at the end of the six thousand, so the righteous have bodies, but they are lifted from the earth, outside the body's comfort zone. Like Moshe on the mountain, the body is a guest and follows the soul. It is called a day of Shabbat, of rest, when one begins to rest from all physicality. But the body has not yet given up its impulses, because the world has not yet been renewed. The "wings" mean that we will no longer be bound by our physical limits, like gravity.
- **From the renewal onwards.** The real reward, with a different body, completely submissive, to enjoy the good.

Questions: mashiah and death

Where does mashiah fit? The Rabbi said that in the grand scheme it is minor, and it falls within the six thousand years. Israel will be sovereign and the nations will recognise God, but the world continues as it is. If mashiah came at the very end of the six thousand, level four might follow immediately.

Why is death still needed? Death and the reunification bring a person back to the level of Adam before the sin. But Adam could still sin, so a further process of rectification follows, lasting a few thousand years through levels three, two and one, to be discussed next time.

Summary

- We are often given the highest level first, then must earn it: Pesah night, the child taught Torah in the womb, and the soul at its creation.
- Level four is the body as a guest, unchanged but silent, like Moshe on the mountain; level five is this world, where the body rules, whether we use it animalistically or in holiness.
- The five levels are degrees of illumination and concealment, like a dial on the soul; in general there are three.
- §92: six thousand years of this world; the seventh millennium, when the righteous are given "wings"; then the renewed world of reward.
- Mashiah comes within the six thousand years and the world continues; full rectification takes thousands of years more.

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